

Muncie Sanitary District Meeting February 5th 2025

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=chXCxnNyvHA
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Meeting Summary: Board of Sanitary Commissioners

Meeting Date: February 5, 2025

Report Publication: Civic Analysis Reporting Desk

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** The regular meeting of the Board of Sanitary Commissioners was called to order at [00:00:30](#) on February 5, 2025, by the presiding officer.
- **Attendance:**
 - **Present:** All sanitary commissioners (No excused absences).
 - **Absent:** None.
 - **Presiding Officer:** Board President.

3. Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** The meeting opened with the recitation of the Pledge of Allegiance [00:00:36](#).
- **Approval of Minutes:** The board considered the minutes from the January 22, 2025 meeting [00:00:41](#). **Action:** Approved by Voice Vote [00:10:04](#).

- **Register of Claims:** The board reviewed the register of claims totaling \$1,237,121.12
00:10:10. **Action:** Approved by Voice Vote 00:10:38.
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4. Substantive Business & Board Action

00:19:42 Professional Services Contract Renewal: John Barlo and Phil Reagan

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Rick Conrad, District Administrator.
- **Deliberation Summary:** Mr. Conrad presented the annual renewal for former District Administrator John Barlo and Phil Reagan. Mr. Barlo brings over 40 years of plant experience and institutional knowledge, assisting staff with plant upgrades and long-term control plan compliance. The previous year's total spend for these consulting contracts was under \$5,000, representing high value for the district.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote 00:21:48.

00:22:06 Release of Retainage: Bowen Engineering Contract

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Dina Cox, Financial Billing Manager.
- **Deliberation Summary:** Ms. Cox requested the release of final retainage to Bowen Engineering in the amount of \$245,900 for the completion of the 2021 Bond projects (specifically CSO 13 and the Maka Park lift station). Board leadership noted this serves as the final closeout step for this bond project, with all work inspected by a third party and accepted by the plant director.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote 00:22:30.

00:23:43 Introduction of Resolution 2024-25 (Nonprofit & Charity Rate Adjustment)

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Board President / District Leadership.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Board leadership introduced a resolution establishing a distinct category and fee structure for churches and charities. Because recent rate adjustments under the federal Long-Term Control Plan mandate (estimated between \$160 million remaining to over \$300 million total) created heavy cost burdens, nonprofits were previously miscategorized under commercial rates. The new resolution establishes a nonprofit rate schedule featuring a \$20 base fee and a \$10 user fee.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Resolution introduced and passed by Voice Vote 00:27:28 to be scheduled for a future public hearing.
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5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- 00:01:20 Mark Abril (Attorney, Liberty Regional Waste District):
Addressed the board regarding the wholesale treatment contract between Liberty

Regional Waste District (representing 1,600-1,700 customers in the Selma area) and the Muncie Sanitary District. He noted that rate adjustments are tied to a specific spreadsheet formula derived from year-end numbers. He requested that the board delay the implementation of their latest bill by 120 days to allow their district time to process the notice and adjust local customer rates accordingly.

- **00:05:24 Alan Cornblau (Muncie Public Library Director):**

Expressed concern that the library's wastewater bill last month more than tripled, adding over \$900 for the month and totaling roughly \$11,000 annually in unbudgeted costs. He requested board consideration and relief regarding the new utility rates.

- **00:06:03 Robert Harmon (Downtown Business Owner):**

Stated he has operated a downtown business for 17 years and saw his sewer bill jump significantly (tripling) despite registering zero water consumption on the billing cycle. He criticized the shift to flat fees over consumption-based billing, raised concerns about equity between commercial properties and residential/Airbnb operations, and expressed frustration regarding the online payment service fee and the elimination of in-person cash payment drop-offs at the local building. *(Note: Board leadership advised Mr. Harmon to speak with Finance Manager Dina Cox after the meeting regarding payment options and billing questions).*

6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **District Administrator Update (00:10:54):** Rick Conrad provided updates on the Levy Tieback Project (awaiting final Army Corps of Engineers approval) and ongoing negotiations with IDEM regarding the Long-Term Control Plan (unfunded federal mandate for combined sewer overflows). The remaining compliance cost is currently estimated at \$160 million (following \$90 million already spent), which could exceed \$300 million depending on regulatory plan approvals.
- **Department Head Update (00:13:31):** Chuck Jones, Director of the Bureau of Water Quality, presented the department's annual recap. Highlights included completing over 24,000 lab analyses, earning the iwea Laboratory Excellence Award, surveying White River mussels and fish populations (noting 47% pollution-intolerant species sampled), expanding the muscle propagation facility (housing over 1,800 mussels, including the state special concern Wavy-rayed Lampmussel), and hosting 492 visitors at the new education facility since June.
- **Staff / Board Announcements:** The next regular meeting is scheduled for Wednesday, February 19, 2025.
- **Adjournment:** The meeting was adjourned by voice vote **00:29:46**.